

THE MANMOHAN-SONIA-RAHUL
TROIKA IS AN ESSENTIAL PART OF
THE PARTY'S CAMPAIGN FOR E-2009

AFP PHOTO/RAVEENDRAN



**THE PARTY IS SCARED OF NAMING A
SUCCESSOR FROM OUTSIDE THE FAMILY
EVEN IF ONLY FOR A COUPLE OF WEEKS.**

PRETENDERS to the THRONE

All of them consider themselves prime minister material but are at best stop-gap arrangements until Rahul Gandhi happens

protocol, practice and convention," said Devendra Dwivedi, Congress leader, pointing out that after Sonia Gandhi appointed Manmohan as prime minister, she has been careful not to undermine his authority. "Appointing a No. 2 could have taken away the prime ministerial aura from the prime minister," he added.

THE HARDER PART

All the blame, though, cannot be placed at the Congress high command's doorstep. Even Manmohan's predecessors never thought of setting up a clear succession mechanism. There have been several instances when the prime minister was out of the country for a month but no other minister was formally given the charge to officiate. Indira Gandhi used to send a fax to her Cabinet authorising a senior minister to preside over the Cabinet meeting only for a specific agenda during her absence. Even when A.B. Vajpayee went for a knee surgery, L.K. Advani was not officially authorised to preside over any Cabinet meeting. According to PMO sources, all the prime ministers were always in touch with the cabinet secretary who would be told verbally to call a meeting of the Cabinet and request the senior-most minister to preside over it only in case of an emergency. Even the deputy prime ministers were not given full powers during the absence of a prime minister.

Within the Congress, it is a story